



HEMANT CHAWLA



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are no answers yet. The reason was obvious: the rapidity with which the threats became real and potent. One minute, India was enjoying its new found place in the sun, the economic envy of the world, celebrating a democracy wondrously intact after 60 years of freedom, and then, with no warning, came the financial crash, followed by a starker image; the bodies on the floor and the funeral processions as a macabre allegory for the way everything had



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trends to look out for

THE CREDIT CRUNCH:

The middle class is in for a traumatic year: most are paying back loans and have maxed out their credit cards. The problems of repayment could lead to significant and long-lasting social upheavals.

LIVING LIFE DWARF-SIZE:

The money squeeze and the fact that most investments, in stock markets or real estate, have tanked, means a major readjustment in lifestyles and monthly spend for those who are used to show and tell extravagance.

STAYCATION TIME: Exotic and frequent holidays are out, the new buzzword is Staycation, stay-at-home vacations, to save money. Less travel, for business or pleasure, is a major challenge for middle and upper class families.

LEVEL PEGGING: The twin crises have brought about greater equality at all levels—no one is insulated anymore—and could mean new social paradigms and unprecedented social and economic changes.

WE ARE THE WORLD: The terror strikes brought Indians together in an unprecedented show of unity. It has also rekindled a spirit of patriotism, which has positive ramifications for Indian society as a whole.

CLOCKWISE:
AUDI R8; BIRD'S
EYE VIEW OF
HIGH-END MALL,
EMPORIO; SHILPA
SHETTY IN A RS 1-
CRORE TARUN
TAHLIANI;
INDULGENCE
AT VARQ

turned around.

It was a rude reversal for a society that was getting accustomed to the idea that the good times were here to stay. For much of the year, it was party time as stock markets registered record highs, salaries and company profits soared and consumerism went stratospheric. Affluenza became the disease of choice, with bigger houses, more cars, larger televisions and younger faces (*read Botox*). Aspiration transformed into